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1 reader reports

1.1 feedback

- overall issues, how the project is currently constituted
 - how does **argument accumulate** in each chapter?
 - * connection between object and theory ought to feel necessary
 - * stronger grounding in book's overall argument
 - * "what the bringing together of queer studies/theory with digital humanities tools and technologies does to transform or critique the field"
 - "what takeaway does this give us that is broadly applicable within that field? What does it reveal about either the technology discussed or queer theory broadly?"
 - where is the **urgency**?
 - * feels like series of term papers
 - * needs strong contribution to the discipline
 - what is the **methodological** intervention?
 - * case needs to be made for the innovativeness of methodology, as it appears to be mostly close reading for now
 - how does close reading work wrt digital tools?
 - "its reliance on close reading seems to work against its goal of working as an introduction to digital tools"
 - * consider *Data Feminism* as a model
- length can be expanded
 - currently between 7000-8000 words

- more space devoted to the political or theoretical intervention of each chapter
- the ambition and length of the chapters expanded
- citing prior Dh work
 - Jason Boyd, Bonni Ruberg, Rahul K Gairola, Ashley Caranto, attendees of first Queering the Digital Humanities course, DHSI in Victoria, Canada, 2018. All four have published substantial work on the topic since that first session.
 - Also look earlier – DH emerged from cultural studies, Stuart Hall’s “Encoding/ Decoding” to give a rich and balanced, historical literature review.
 - adding previously-published work that has appeared since the author completed the PhD thesis
- title change
 - Queer Revisions of Language Technology: Contemporary Counter-Codes of Language Data
- writing style
 - ensure that the writing is as lucid and accessible as possible so that a wide swathe of reads – not just data scholars – can access the important literary, DH, and LGBTQIA+ readings.

1.2 response

1.2.1 How does the argument accumulate over the chapters?

Language technologies reduce language complexity to make it computable. Words are removed from their original context, cleaned and standardized, so that they can be stored and analyzed at scale.

EITHER

These increasingly automated processes encode dominant logics and extractive incentives onto language data, creating known issues with data sovereignty, privacy, and most recently, bias, as AI tools.

OR

As a result of this process, dominant forms of language meanings are reproduced into digital realms, creating known issues like bias and discrimination, as with current AI tools.

This book breaks open and re-works technologies for analyzing language about sex, gender and sexuality. It takes a close look into technologies like web scraping, text analysis, machine learning, among others. Then, drawing from concepts in Queer Studies and related fields, it re-works these technologies into new analytical methodologies that open up, rather than reduce, novel readings of language data.

Each of the five chapters considers a different technology for working with language. For that technology, the chapter identifies a technical constraint that reduces or flattens language meaning. For example, chapter 2, "Text Analysis," explores the technology of quantitative text analysis, and within that technology, the constraint of iteration: a logic of repetition that allows computers to execute the same action across large collections of text, one word at a time. This constraint, which allows quantitative text analysis to transform texts at large scales, amplifies frequent patterns in language while suppressing minor differences and details. The chapter then takes Judith Butler's concept of Gender Performativity, which describes gender as a social and behavioral phenomenon that becomes intelligible through habit or repetition, to re-work computational iteration into a new text analysis practice for studying gender. Unlike typical text analysis projects, which visualizes dominant semantic patterns and relationships, this new methodology uses quantification to surface the idiosyncracies and nuances in word meaning.

The table below sketches the relationship between technology, technical constraint, and conceptual tool across the book's five chapters.

Chapter	Technology	Technical Constraint	Conceptual Tool
1. Text Capture	Web Scraping	Protocol	Borderlands Theory ¹
2. Text Analysis	Quantitative Text Analysis	Iteration	Gender Performativity ²
3. Text Preservation	Markup Language	Containment	Dis-Identification ³
4. Text Display	Display	Abstraction	Enfleshment ⁴
5. Text Generation	Machine Learning	Aggregation	Body Dysphoria ⁵

Each chapter tests its methodology on a different literary object. While the earlier chapters explore traditional works of queer literature (Gloria Anzaldúa's *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza*, 1987; Virginia Woolf's *Orlando: A Biography*, 1928; Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, 1890) the latter chapters take on more eclectic source material, some of which features heterosexual characters, from science fiction, electronic literature and reality TV (Octavia Butler's *Dawn*, 1987; Entropy8Zuper!'s *skinonskinonskin*, 1999; *Love is Blind*, 2020+). The expansion of source material points new potential orientations around queerness based on embodiment and mutual feeling, following Butler's famous call for queerness which is "never fully owned, but always and only redeployed, twisted, queered from a prior usage and in the direction of urgent and expanding political purposes."⁶ (173).

Part of re-defining "queer" for the future involves developing a robust conceptual toolset for doing resistance work. As the earlier chapters show, Queer Studies' initial (and necessary) emphasis on identity politics offers resistance methods from *within* systems of power. The first three chapters thus explore ways for re-working protocols and structures in order to resist totalizing logics. However, the latter chapters, which draw from more recent Trans- and Black Feminist-inflected work in Queer Studies, foreground methodologies of resistance that work *alongside* and *beyond* these systems. These methodologies center on material and embodied experiences in ways that are not contained within existing systems. The book argues that both approaches, working *inside* and working *beyond*, are necessary for resistance, which must shift between opposition and collaboration, from co-opting to co-creating within and without oppressive forces.

¹Anzaldúa, Gloria. *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza*. Aunt Lute Books. 1987.

²Butler, Judith. *Bodies That Matter: On the Discursive Limits of "Sex"*. Routledge, 2011.

³Muñoz, José Esteban. *Disidentifications: Queers of Color and the Performance of Politics*. José Esteban Muñoz. University of Minnesota Press, 1999.

⁴Musser, Amber Jamilla. *Sensual Excess: Queer Femininity and Brown Jouissance*. NYU Press, 2018.

⁵Prosser, Jay. *Second Skins: The Body Narratives of Transsexuality*. Columbia University Press. 1998.

⁶Butler, *Bodies That Matter*, 173.

1.2.2 What is the urgency?

Language technologies are increasingly centralized, black-boxed, and automated. This book offers a blueprint for how language technologies work from the inside. It examines a "stack" of technologies that progress from preliminary to advanced. The book begins with three chapters on the preliminary processes of gathering, cleaning, and structuring text ("Text Capture," "Text Analysis," "Text Preservation"). Then, the fourth and fifth chapters proceed to the more advanced tasks of screen display and machine learning ("Text Display," "Text Generation").

This scaffolded approach builds a knowledge base over a variety of tools through the course of the book. Through exposure to the logics of computational procedures, readers learn technical strategies to re-work the all but inevitable language technologies that proliferate around them.

1.2.3 What is the methodological intervention?

The main intervention is the close reading of digital tools, a methodology that it adapts from Matthew Kirschenbaum.

"its reliance on close reading seems to work against its goal of working as an introduction to digital tools"

The chapter then applies a concept from Queer Studies, which it uses as a conceptual *tool* to re-work this constraint to surface what has been suppressed.